



How can grouping outputs/deliverables obscure the link between outputs and higher-level outcomes?

In some strategy, planning, implementation, and reporting systems, 'outputs' ('deliverables' or 'activities') are gathered into larger groups (e.g. 'outputs groups' or 'outputs classes'). This makes it simpler for decision-makers to specify and control funding because they can just allocate funding to such larger groups of outputs rather than individual outputs. This is useful, but fine-grained information can be lost if the links between individual outputs and outcomes are only reported at a group level. To understand this, it is easiest to think in terms of a DoView strategy/outcomes diagram.

There is no problem where all of the individual output boxes within an output group happen to just be focused on a single higher-level step or outcome. In such a case, information about exactly which outcomes each individual output box links to is not obscured because all of the outputs just link to the single higher-level outcomes box.

But as we know, to properly portray reality, we need to allow any output box to potentially link to any higher-level step or outcome box within a DoView strategy/outcomes diagram. See the Do Not Silo Steps Under Outcomes Explainer (B16). Situations often arise where a lower-level individual output box links to more than one higher-level step or outcome box. If this happens a great deal, then a visual representation that only shows the links between output group heading and high-level steps or outcomes is not sufficiently detailed. Most outcomes group headings will link to most higher-level outcomes boxes within such a representation, but the reader will not be able to work out the specific link between individual outputs and higher-level steps or outcomes.

Within DoView Planning, the solution to this is to provide the whole DoView strategy/outcomes diagram in addition to whatever summaries you may have, just showing how output group headings link to higher-level steps or outcomes. With a fully articulated DoView diagram, the reader can look at the entire structure and see the linkages that exist from each lower-level output box to each higher-level step or outcome box. They can then determine from such a fine-grained visualization, whether there is, or is not, sufficient 'line-of-sight' alignment between outputs and outcomes.

Source: DOVIEW PLANNING AND PRACTICAL OUTCOMES THEORY HANDBOOK (2025). DoView Planning.Org. Copyright Dr Paul W Duignan.